

Creatures are affected in order from those with the lowest hit points to the highest.

Dice Quasits: An oversized dice cup on the table is covered by a stack of books. Inside the cup are three dice quasits (see the sidebar). When they hear the characters, they call out in wheedling, whiny voices to be released, promising to serve anyone who frees them.

AREA 6.18: AVNAS'S FORGE

Like area 6.17, this area remains unpixelated because of the chaotic clockwork energy it channels. This hot, poorly ventilated chamber contains a makeshift forge connected by pipes to the larger forge at area 6.16. The fire burns blue here due to the chemicals Avnas uses in her work. A creature with fire immunity might be able to creep through the pipes that connect the two forges.

A number of nonworking clockwork creations are scattered around the room, including constructs shaped of sword blades, corkscrews, and jagged drill bits; booby-trapped armor that lops off its wearer's head or explodes when a belt-buckle is pushed; and fragmented metal limbs that crawl around. If the characters search the room thoroughly, they awaken three **iron cobras**^M that attack.

AREA 6.19: GUARDROOM

This area is identical to area 6.8, and contains three pixelated **merregons**^M and three pixelated **veterans**.

AREA 6.20: GUARDROOM

This area is identical to area 6.8, and contains three pixelated **merregons**^M and three pixelated **veterans**.

AREA 6.21: MORGUE

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. The room is cold, and the white glowing bricks in the wall glow dimly. Numerous long tables fill the area, and the walls are lined with large drawers, some open. Most of the tables are covered with blocky humanoid figures whose flesh is gray or yellow, and which is marked by irregular ridges, gaps, and holes. Similar figures lie in the drawers. In one corner of the room is a white tub 10 feet across. The tub is streaked with square scales of brown-gray slime, has a large grated drain, and features a crown of square gray pipes hanging from the ceiling above it. A faint smell of decay

DICE QUASIT

A rare variant among its demonic kind, a dice **quasit** can use its shapechanging ability to transform into what appears to be a large gaming die shaped of metal or stone. In this form, the dice quasit can see its surroundings, can speak, and can move by hopping or scuttling.

When rolled in its dice form, a dice quasit has a certain amount of control over the result of the roll. It is thus a perfect companion for a cheating gambler—especially as it does not radiate magic as enchanted dice would. A character using the dice quasit in a game has advantage on any ability checks made as part of the game. A dice quasit is always eager to serve a master—but it always attempts to corrupt that master, goading them into ever-greater acts of risk-taking, chaos, and evil.

STYX MIST

Vargo has deemed it advantageous for certain areas of the cube to not become pixelated. To accomplish this, the skull lord had Avnas set up a number of jury-rigged systems of pipes and pumps that constantly mist Styx water into the air.

In areas that are Styx misted, the pipes and pumps are noticeable where they run along the ceiling and walls, terminating in a large bucket of Styx water periodically refilled by pixelated guards. The Styx-water mist makes everything in an area damp and dripping. Pixelated creatures find the mist unpleasant but not harmful. Exposure to the mist is of no benefit to creatures under the effect of the pixelating curse, though the bucket of Styx water can be used to end the curse as normal.

fills the room except near the tub, which carries the scent of lye.

Unpixelated. The metal slabs and wall drawers of this morgue are mostly filled with human, hobgoblin, and duergar dead. Stripped of valuables and partially dissected, they number a hundred or more.

Every body in the room is an undead creature, culled from the endless supply of bodies at area 6.39 and raised by the skull lord using necromantic rituals. In total, forty-three pixelated **skeletons** and seventy-four pixelated **zombies** are here. Each has the following changes to its normal statistics:

- Its alignment is lawful neutral.
- It has telepathy out to a range of 120 feet, but can use it to communicate only with other pixelated creatures.
- It is immune to the frightened condition.
- It has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide while in a pixelated area.

The zombies and skeletons normally lie immobile until commanded to action by the skull lord. However, if the characters destroy more than six bodies, the rest of the undead all rise on the next round and attack. If Vargo is not present, the undead do not pursue characters out of the room.

Acid Bath. The tub is an automated body disposal device. Whenever an object is placed in the tub (or a creature steps into it), a deluge of acid pours down from the pipes above. This deals 21 (6d6) acid damage to the creature at the start of each of its turns. A dead body in the tub is dissolved and drained away to nothing in 2d4 rounds.

AREA 6.22: SURGERY

If he has not been encountered already, Sladek the pixelated **mage** is 50 percent likely to be found here, doing his own alchemical experiments or assisting with the skull lord's. See area 6.11B for more information on the mage.

This room of blue and green tile is kept damp and unpixelated by a Styx-water spraying device (see the "Styx Mist" sidebar).

Bright light fills this area from two *driftglobes* that hover in the center of the room, as well as glowing panels on the wall. Half the room is dominated by a surgical table. Around it, cabinets hold knives, scalpels, and other medical equipment. Sinks along one wall

produce a flow or shower of normal water. A closet contains surgical smocks, while another closet is filled with severed heads—victims of the skull lord’s surgeries. A third closet contains twenty vials of special acid that dissolves flesh but does not harm bone or brain tissue.

In one cabinet near the surgical area are Vargo’s notes, written in Infernal in two styles of handwriting (for two of its heads). Short and unembellished, the notes describe experiments designed to allow the skull lord to add new heads to its body—as well as speculation on the most effective means of determining a creature’s intelligence.

AREA 6.23: LABORATORY

If he has not been encountered already, Sladek the pixelated **mage** is 50 percent likely to be in this room when the characters enter. See area 6.11B for more information on the mage.

This room is kept damp and unpixelated by a Styx-water spraying device (see the “Styx Mist” sidebar). The huge chamber is dominated by alchemical equipment: beakers, flasks and alembics, bubbling liquids, and strange slow-moving flames of various colors. Additionally, several glass-and-steel tanks hold living experiments—the horrible remnants of the fiendish work once carried out here. Breaking any of the tanks requires a successful DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check.

Green Slime. If the glass is broken, all creatures within 5 feet of the tank must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or be covered by a mass of green slime. More slime erupts out to cover an area 5 feet on a side at the center of the room. On initiative count 10 starting the following round, the slime spreads 5 feet horizontally and vertically until it covers an area 15 feet on a side. See “Dungeon Hazards” in chapter 5 of the *Dungeon Master’s Guide* for information on green slime.

Ochre Jelly. If the glass of its tank is shattered, this **ochre jelly** attacks.

Oblex Spawn. This tank is filled with red slime that constantly heaves and changes shape, sending forth limbs that melt back into the mass. If any character examines the slime for more than a few moments, it presses up against the glass as it forms a mushy caricature of that character’s face. If the glass is shattered, the slime is released as an **oblex spawn**^M.

Spiked Creature. This tank contains a water dispenser and food dispenser similar to those in area 6.11. In the opposite corner is what appears to be an earthen lump of light brown pyramidal spikes, about the size of a small barrel.

If the characters approach the tank, the mass rises to its feet and presses itself against the glass nearest to them. It has a vaguely humanoid form with arms and legs, but no facial features or visible eyes—only perfectly triangular spikes. The unknown creature then scratches on the glass as it watches the characters walk around the room.

A *true seeing* spell reveals that the spike creature is a human infected by a disease developed in this laboratory—something similar to the pixelating curse. The creature desires humanoid contact though it cannot speak. A *dispel magic* or *cure disease* spell

returns it to normal, but the human is quite mad from being kept in this state for many years. If subject to a *greater restoration* spell, the character is cured and can communicate. Full immersion in the Styx sea also cures both the disease and the madness. If this unfortunate test subject is cured, who they are and how they came to be here is left for you to determine.

Hand Creature. This tank contains a water dispenser and food dispenser similar to those in area 6.11. Pacing back and forth in the tank is a pink creature with two arms and two legs whose body is covered with hands. The creature’s face, feet, elbows, shoulders, and thighs are festooned with hands, with no facial features visible.

As with the spiked creature, a *true seeing* spell reveals that this is a human subject of terrible experiments. The creature is completely lost in its own world, and it paces in circles even if its glass tank is broken. It can be cured of its affliction in the same manner as the spiked creature (see above). If cured, the unfortunate character’s origin and identity are left to you to determine.

AREA 6.24: MAXIMUM SECURITY PRISON

This room was used as a prison for creatures that had offended Earl Andromalius in some way. When the pixelating curse overtook Cube 1717, the pixelated soldiers released the prisoners here—including the skull lord, Vargo.

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. Numerous deep oubliettes are set into the floor throughout this room, whose unpleasant, glaring white light comes from glowing white bricks in the walls. The mouths of the oubliettes are blocked by cubic gray metal bars, most of which appear to be bent and damaged. Some of the bars are covered with a decorative mosaic pattern. A gray box connected to blocky pipes is attached to the wall between the doors.

Unpixelated. The gray metal box contains numerous wires, switches, and buttons that once opened and closed the barred doors of the oubliettes. The mosaic markings on the bars are Infernal inscriptions, noting the crimes for which prisoners were incarcerated. If the characters read all the writing on the bars, they discover Vargo the skull lord’s cell, whose bars read: “*CRIMES: Sedition, sedition, sedition • PUNISHMENTS: Decapitated and heads fused into one body; raised; 1 million life sentences.*”

Empty Prison. Characters looking inside the oubliettes see that they are 30 feet deep and note their foul scent. Pixelated chains hang from the walls 10 feet below the top of each pit, from which prisoners were once hung by their extremities.

In some cells, the bodies of prisoners still hang from the chains. In others, those bodies have rotted and fallen apart. Though the dead are pixelated, it’s clear that all were the unfortunate subjects of cruel magic experiments at the hands of Earl Andromalius.

AREA 6.25: MIDDLE-LEVEL BARRACKS

This area is identical to area 6.11, set up as an open space lined with multiple layers of cell-like rooms once

inhabited by the cube's Acheronian soldiers. Some of the cells contain minor personal items that once belonged to the dead, but nothing else of interest. (Vargo doesn't yet have enough soldiers to need this level of the barracks).

Welcome Home. If the skull lord becomes aware of the characters' presence in the cube but the situation doesn't immediately turn into a fight, it uses this area as a prison to hold the intruders (see "The Skull Lord's Plan")—but with a dark twist. Using the authority over all pixelated creatures that comes from being attuned to the Six-Face Throne, the skull lord commands the balhannoth and the adult oblex (see face 5 and *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for information on those creatures). Using its telepathic and reality-warping powers, the balhannoth turns this area into an exact duplicate of a real place one of the characters most wants to be: their hometown, their favorite tavern, the port town they were in before they came to the island, or even some place of respite the character has only ever dreamed of visiting.

To carry out this plan, the skull lord or one of its allies (most likely Bunch the berbalang or Sladek the pixelated mage) engages the characters in negotiations or distracting small talk for the 10 minutes

it takes for the balhannoth to transform the area. The characters are then told that a dimensional portal in the cube can take them home, whereupon they are led to area 6.25. As soon as they pass through the doorway into this area, that doorway disappears behind them.

Everything in the new environment appears to be real. Moreover, the characters are also greeted by up to 1d4 + 1 people or creatures that seem to belong at the new location—all of them manifested by the oblex. If the area would normally have a larger group of people, they are unexpectedly absent or show up later, but no more than two to five other creatures are ever seen at the same time.

In reality, the characters remain in the barracks as transformed by the balhannoth. The skull lord simply wants them to waste time figuring out how to get out of this false environment while the pixelating curse overcomes them.

Among the many things likely to give away the false nature of this homecoming, any object created by the balhannoth is clearly a fake. Books turn out to be filled with blank paper, mechanical devices are crude, nonfunctioning duplicates, gold and jewels turn out to be made of paste or tin, and so forth. Characters who move to the edge of the area also quickly discover that it has fixed boundaries, as the balhannoth has reshaped the barracks' existing walls to hem them in.

The faint sulfur smell of the oblex can also be noted around any of its simulacra with a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check. Because the oblex has no knowledge of NPCs known to the characters, the absence of such NPCs at the false location is also a giveaway.

If the characters attack the simulacra or discover the balhannoth where it hides within some feature of the false location, both the balhannoth and the oblex attack at once and summon nearby pixelated guards to aid them.

If one or more characters reach mental level 3 of the pixelating curse while in this area, the balhannoth telepathically fills them in on the plan. Players of those characters can be encouraged to secretly roleplay this development, joining in on deceiving the other characters and keeping them in the false location while the pixelating curse runs its course.

AREA 6.26: TREASURY

The 20-foot-tall door to this room is inscribed with a carving of the five heads of Tiamat, still recognizable despite their pixelation. The door is locked, and features a large keyhole covered with pixelated dragon designs. A *glyph of warding* inscribed upon the door by the skull lord can be noted only with a successful DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation) check. It triggers a *finger of death* spell (save DC 18) upon any creature except the skull lord that touches the door.

The door opens only to a key the skull lord wears around its neck, but it can be picked with a successful DC 30 Dexterity check using thieves' tools. It can also be attacked (it has the same statistics as the exterior doors of the cube).

